



Figure 1: Open source versus free software

Software Foundation. The OSI is an organisation that focuses entirely on gaining support for open source software. The idea behind the OSI is to get more companies behind open source by allowing them to write their own open source licences, and have those licences certified by the Open Source Initiative (<http://opensource.org/licenses/index.html>).

GNU licences

The Free Software Movement is headed by the Free Software Foundation, a fund-raising organisation for the GNU project. The GNU General Public License (GPL) is a means of implementing a concept called copyleft, which attempts to negate copyright for the purposes of collaborative software development.

GPL (V2 or V3) is a copyleft licence that requires anyone who distributes your code or a derivative work to make the source available under the same terms. V3 is similar to V2, but further restricts use in hardware that forbids software alterations.

The GPL, in brief, provides that anyone distributing a compiled program which is licensed under the GPL must also provide source code, and is free to make modifications to the program as long as those modifications are also made available in source code form. This guarantees that once a program is ‘opened’ to the community, it cannot be ‘closed’ except with the consent of every author of every piece of code (even the modifications) within it.

Most Linux programs, Git, WordPress, etc, are licensed under the GPL.

There are two versions of GPL in use—GPLv2 and GPLv3. The latter contains compatibility regulations that make it easier than before to combine GPL code with code that was published under different licences. GPLv3 also addresses digital rights management. It addresses what would happen if the terms of the licence are violated and specifies the cure for the violation.

To use the GPL, you have to include certain information in the software’s code, along with a copy of the licence. Further details and the licence itself can be found at www.gnu.org/licenses/licenses.en.html.

Another flavour of GPL is the GNU Lesser General Public License (LGPL). Because GPL requires other software with parts of licensed code to also be licensed under the GPL, developers cannot use GPL-licensed code for paid and proprietary software. The LGPL negates this aspect of the GPL since it does not require other projects with parts of the code to be similarly licensed. It grants fewer rights to a work than the standard GPL.

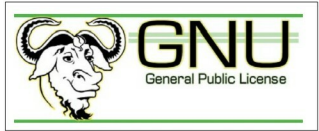


Figure 2: GNU-GPL logo

BSD and the Mozilla License

Other open source licences like the BSD and Mozilla License also allow redistribution, but have fewer rules regarding the conditions for redistribution. The BSD License allows anyone to redistribute the work or any derivative without any source, if such is the desired path. Some people believe that these licences grant users more freedom, since they include a ‘superset’ of the rights granted by the GPL. Other people believe that only the GPL truly respects users’ freedoms by guaranteeing that no one can co-opt their original work.

A ‘permissive’ licence is simply a non-copyleft open source licence — one that guarantees the freedoms to use, modify and redistribute, but permits proprietary derivative works. BSD is a permissive licence that lets people do anything with your code with proper attribution and without warranty.

The Mozilla Public License (MPL 2.0) is maintained by the Mozilla Foundation. This licence attempts to be a compromise between the permissive BSD License and the corresponding GPL.

Apache License

The Apache License is also permissive, and allows express grant of patent rights from the contributor to the recipient. Because some licences can be applied only to copyrights and not patents, this flexibility would be an obvious factor in a developer’s choice of licence. Redistributing code also has special requirements, mostly pertaining to giving proper credit to those who have worked on the code and to maintaining the same licence. Also, the Apache License states that no one can take these rights away once they’re granted. In other words, you don’t need to worry that after

you’ve created some awesome derivative of the licensed code, someone down the road will swoop in and say, “Sorry, you can’t use this code any more.”



Figure 3: BSD License



Figure 4: Mozilla License

MIT License

The MIT License is a permissive one, the wording for which is short and to the point. It lets people do anything they want with your code as long as they provide attribution back to you and don’t hold you